



sorry state of the state police units—its Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) was more of an investigative wing without the crack assault component like the Special Weapons and Tactics (SWAT) squads. The police did not have the ability to even hold the terrorists at bay until the arrival of the NSG and the panicky state government had to call in the navy's Marine Commandos.

The NSG, based in Manesar, Haryana, arrived in Mumbai more than six hours later. It had to drive down to Delhi airport because its helicopters could not fly at night. It waited for an IL-76 aircraft, supposed to be on 24-hour standby notice, but away in Chandigarh. When it landed in Mumbai and the NSG commandos finally boarded BEST buses for the siege area, it took them over two days to flush terrorists out from three locations. Some of it had to do with the utter lack of equipment. Forget the high-end stuff like UAVs or mobile command posts, troopers fought without basics like bulletproof vests and ballistic helmets. Minutes before they took off from Delhi, the Black Cats were frantically dialling for ballistic vests to be delivered at the airport. "The assault forces were not equipped with special counter-terror arms—clothing, night vision, laser viewfinders, ballistic shields, helmets with communication devices," says Colonel (retd) Jonathan Fighel of the International Policy Centre for Counter-Terror, Israel.

Set up mega city policing

Clearly, Indian metros need to end their dependence on a massive home ministry force like the NSG centred near the capital—a relic of the 1980s insurgencies in Punjab and Jammu and Kashmir. These specially trained and equipped forces numbering not more than 100 need to be raised in every Indian metro like fire brigades, ready to tackle commando operations and hostage situations. They need to be built around a nucleus of battle-hardened troopers exposed to training with army special forces, kept on a 24-hour alert and equipped with cutting edge weaponry and night vision devices capable of breaking sieges and rescuing hostages. The Government has announced the setting up of regional NSGs to take care of emergencies in the short term.



BHASKAR PAUL

Also, most city police forces are ill-equipped to deal with ordinary crimes, leave alone such exigencies. On an average, there are 126 police personnel to one lakh people. In developed countries, the ratio varies from 300 to 500 policemen to one lakh people. "If you take into account the quality of education and training of police personnel, the police are just not equipped to prevent terror attacks of this nature. You have lathi-wielding policemen in the 21st century. You are trying to fight a 21st century threat with a 19th century police force," says Ajai Sahni, counter-terrorism expert and executive director of the Institute for Conflict Management.

There are other areas that need to be reformed urgently. K.P.S. Gill, former Punjab DGP,

POLICEMEN NEED TO BE TRAINED IN GATHERING FORENSIC EVIDENCE.

NEW YORK ALONE HAS ABOUT 50,000 CCTV UNITS, MORE THAN INDIA'S TOTAL. MORE SURVEILLANCE IS REQUIRED.